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Robert and the three envelopes

Robert lived in a flat in a tall grey building in the middle of a big city. When he looked out of his window, he could only see more tall grey buildings and lots of roads and noisy traffic. Sometimes, this made Robert feel sad. He liked watching television programmes about climbing mountains and going to places where there were waterfalls, lakes and beautiful beaches. He loved reading stories about ships that sailed across the sea and about people who lived on strange islands or in other exciting places.



‘Why must we live here in the city?’ he asked his mother.

‘Because my job at the busy hospital is here, Robert. But perhaps we can have a nice holiday in the countryside next summer. Would you like that?’

‘Oh yes!’ Robert laughed.

That night, when Robert went to bed he thought about going on holiday. But then he remembered something. Last year, his mother said the same thing, but they didn’t go to the countryside. They spent the summer at home in the city because they didn’t have enough money to buy train tickets or stay in a hotel in the countryside.

On the school bus the next morning, Robert looked through the window and saw a boat on the river in the middle of the city.



'I'd like to go on a boat or on a big ship one day,' he thought. Then he saw a train on a bridge near the city station. 'I'd like to go on a fast train one day,' he thought. Then he looked up into the sky and saw a plane. 'I'd like to go on a plane one day too. I'd like to look out of its windows at the countryside below,' he thought.

When school finished, Robert didn't want to go home by bus. He decided to walk. He walked past the shoe factory, the chemist's and then past the police station at the bottom of the hill. Then he walked past the supermarket and the bread shop. But then he started to feel tired, so he sat down for a minute on a wall outside the post office.

Then a strange thing happened. A big black and white bird flew down from the sky. It had an envelope in its beak. It dropped the envelope on Robert's foot and then flew away again. Robert picked the letter up. On the envelope, it said 'Read me'. So Robert did!

Robert opened the envelope. There was a piece of blue paper inside with some writing on it. Robert read it carefully.

‘If you find me, go and look in your biggest, oldest book.’

Robert couldn’t understand the message but he put the piece of paper in his pocket.

When he got home he sat down and looked at the message again.

‘“In your biggest, oldest book”,’ he thought. ‘What does that mean?’

Robert decided to try something. He got a chair from the kitchen and carried it into the living room. Then he put the chair in front of the bookcase and stood on it. The biggest and oldest book was at the top of the bookcase. Robert took it down from the shelf. It was very heavy.



Robert opened it and a thin envelope fell out. Inside the envelope was a little book. Its pages were yellow because they were so old, and they had lots of numbers on them. He jumped down and ran back into the kitchen to show the little book to his mother.

‘What’s this?’ he asked her. His mother took the book and opened it.

‘It’s the kind of book that banks gave people a long time ago,’ she said. ‘This person had lots of money in the bank. And look! There’s a name on the front. It says “Helen Bird”. I don’t believe it! That was my grandmother’s name! I’ll go to the bank tomorrow and show this to Mr Flag.’

When Robert's mother gave the old book to Mr Flag the next day, he looked at it very carefully, picked up his telephone and spoke to someone in an excited kind of way. Then he put the telephone down again. He had a big smile on his face.

'Well,' he said, 'you must thank your son for finding this little book. Your grandmother left all this money in our bank for you a long time ago, but we didn't know that until now. What are you going to buy with it?'

Robert's mother smiled. 'Something that Robert wants very much.'

When Robert came home from school later that afternoon, he found a bigger envelope on the kitchen table. 'Open it!' his mother said.

Inside the envelope were two plane tickets and two train tickets and two boat tickets!

'Robert, Mr Flag at the bank says we've got enough money now. We're going to have a wonderful holiday.'

'Because of your grandmother's little book?' Robert asked.

'Yes,' his mother said.

Robert looked out of the window at the sky. He couldn't see the big black and white bird high in the clouds, but he knew the bird was there.



'And because of the big black and white bird!' Robert smiled.

'What do you mean?' his mother asked.

'That's my secret!' Robert said.